Newsren

Understand the news. Connect the dots. Build stronger arguments.

The problem

Students are told to “read more” to strengthen their essays. But reading an article does not automatically help them identify its significance, connect events or apply evidence to an argument. Long articles compete with school and limited downtime, while social feeds offer fragments without context. Saved links become scattered and examples are difficult to recall. Students may know how to structure an argument but lack substantial evidence to support it.

Who it’s for

Newsren serves students who are curious about the world but struggle to build a reading habit. They enjoy games, visuals and conversation, yet find traditional news intimidating or exhausting. They lose focus during lengthy explanations, feel unsure which details matter, and become discouraged by advice to simply “read more.” They want to form opinions and write confidently. They need an approachable starting point, manageable explanations and connections that make information meaningful.

The solution

Newsren is a mobile-first web app guided by a friendly pixel-computer companion, with two connected modes:

- **Explore:** Choose a topic, browse articles and understand what happened and why it matters. Follow explained links to historical, parallel or contrasting events, then save the gist and sources into a personal evidence Bank.
- **Question:** Enter an essay question. Newsren is designed to identify relevant saved evidence, explain what it supports or challenges, and highlight limitations. When evidence is missing, students can discover additional articles, save examples and return to the same question.

A student journey

A student reads about digital tools used during protests in Kenya, then explores connections to platform influence and surveillance. They begin to understand a tension: technology can expand participation while enabling control. Later, when considering *“Is modern technology a benefit or a threat to democracy?”*, these connected stories provide contrasting evidence for a thoughtful argument.

Why Newsren is different

Newsren combines discovery, explanation, connections and evidence retrieval. Its companion makes exploration approachable, while the Bank preserves understanding alongside links. Clear attribution helps students recognise the value and limits of each example.

The aim is independent thinking—not complete essays or memorised arguments.

Current stage and success

The prototype includes six themes, real curated articles, explained connections and a persistent evidence Bank. Automated matching and external discovery remain under development and live verification. Success means clearer understanding, easier evidence retrieval and stronger application -not longer scrolling.